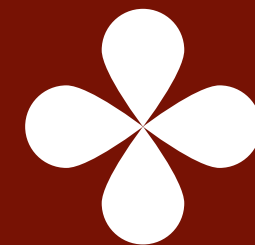


Yabesra Ewnetu and Catalina Giraldo

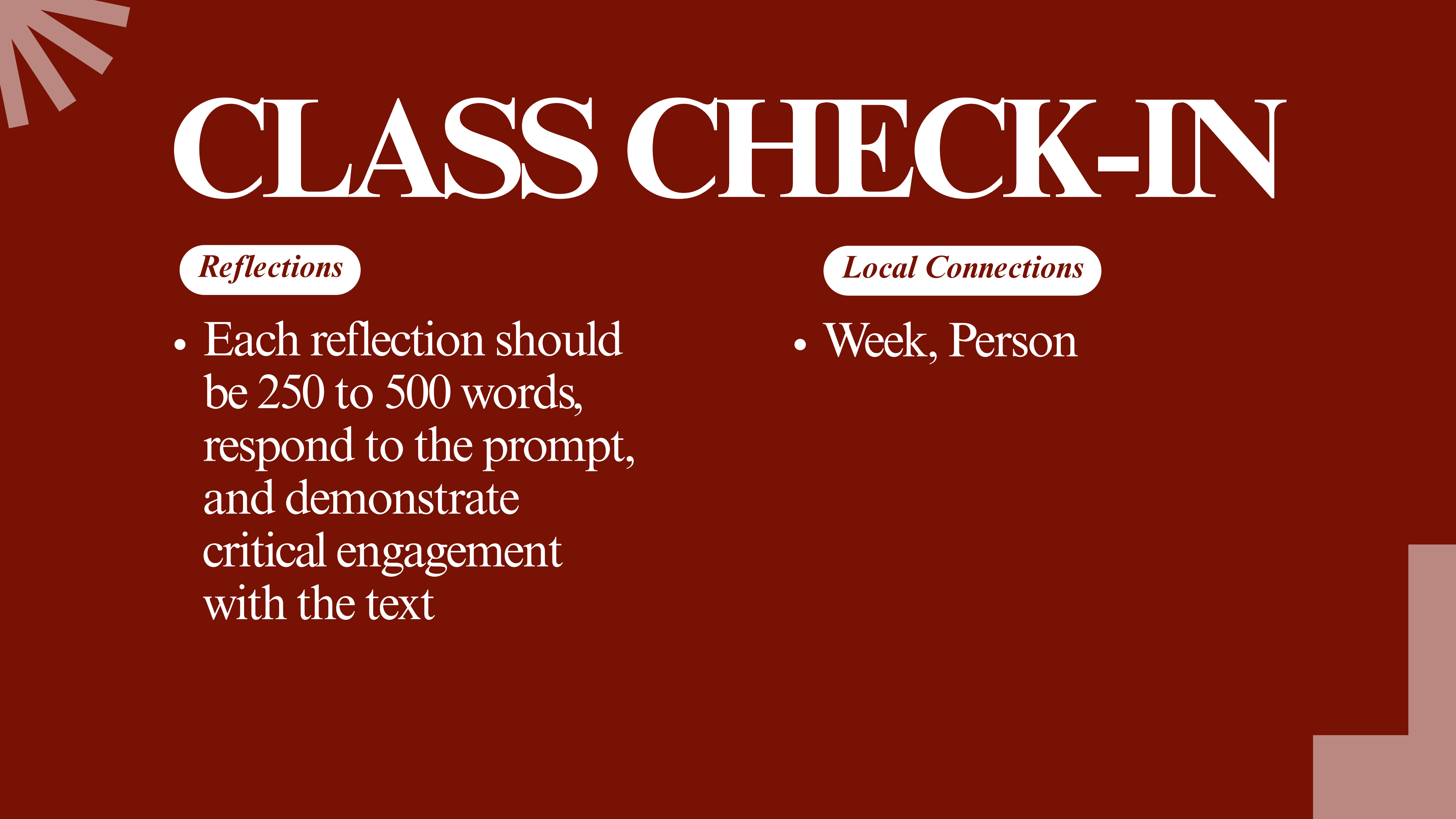


RAISING WOMEN IN POWER



at Duke and Beyond

Spring 2026



CLASS CHECK-IN

Reflections

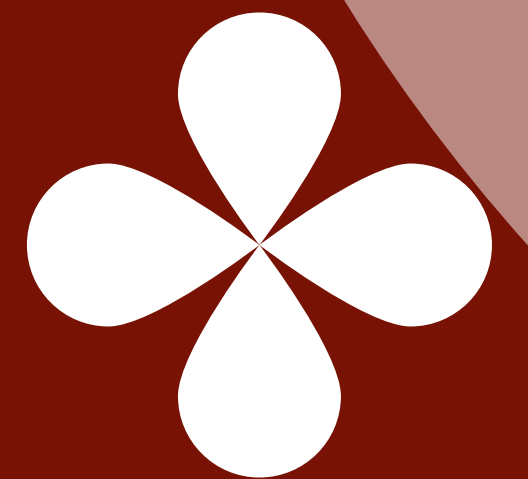
- Each reflection should be 250 to 500 words, respond to the prompt, and demonstrate critical engagement with the text

Local Connections

- Week, Person

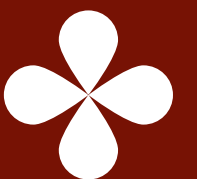


GLOBAL PERSPECTIVES & CELEBRATION OF WOMANHOOD



*ICE BREAKER:

- WHAT IS THE WEIRDEST FOOD YOU'VE EVER EATEN?
- IF YOU COULD HAVE ANY FICTIONAL CHARACTER AS YOUR FRIEND, WHO WOULD IT BE?
- WHAT'S YOUR GO-TO KARAOKE SONG?





MAIN IDEA

Womanhood has been defined by the intersection of globalization and culture

There is no single, universal experience or definition of "womanhood." It is a concept that is constructed and understood differently across the world, shaped by the intersection of global forces (such as international relations and colonialism) and local cultural practices.

Essential Questions

- Why is there no universal narrative of womanhood?
- How do global and local forces interact to shape the experience of gender in a particular place?
- In what ways does using the U.S. as the primary lens limit our understanding of gender globally?
- How do the specific "groups" or communities we belong to (e.g., sororities, majors, cultural groups) shape our personal connection to or understanding of womanhood?



CELEBRATION OF WOMEN

🇮🇹 Italia 🇮🇹

Women's Day in Italy (March 8th), not a national holiday



First Woman Prime Minister:
Giorgia Meloni



Veneration of Mary in the Catholic Church

- The figure of Mary has made the role of mothers sacred: emphasis on sacrifice, care of others and devotion to the family.

National holidays:

- L'Immacolata Concezione (The Immaculate Conception), on Dec 8th
- L'assunzione (The assumption) on Aug 15th



Tahani Hassan

- **Women keep 100% of their wealth in marriage - His money is her money, and her money is her money.**
 - **Women keep their last name after marriage (Preserves her identity & lineage, and does not become “owned” by her husband).**
 - **Women receive mehr (a bridal gift) in whatever she chooses (Car, 10k, horse, literally anything).**
-
- **After childbirth, the mother stays home for 40 days. Female relatives and the community help care for her and on the 40th day there is a party to celebrate the mother & baby. This is to protect the mother's health, allow for a full physical recovery, prevent heavy work, & celebrate her and her baby.**

Kenya 🇰🇪

23.3% of Parliament seats held by women (2024)



A new Women's Empowerment Index estimates that **40.6% of women in Kenya are empowered** in 2025, up from 29.3% in 2020. Urban women tend to be more empowered than rural women.

Girls and women have **high literacy and school completion rates** — around *91% female literacy* and almost equal primary and secondary school completion compared to boys.



Jewish



Bat Mitzvah

Celebrating taking on
religious
responsibilities

Modern Narratives of Resilient, Powerful Jewish Women

Anne Frank, RBG,
family members, etc.

Sally Priesand: first female Rabbi in the 1970s

*“Since then, women
have become cantors,
educators, rabbis,
scholars, and powerful
voices across Jewish
life. In Progressive
communities, women
now play an equal role
in nearly every aspect
of Jewish ritual and
leadership.”*

ETHIOPIA: ASHENDA FESTIVAL

Ethiopia's Ashenda-Annual celebration of femininity

Location: Tigray & Amhara regions, Northern Ethiopia.

The Story:

Every August, Ashenda marks the end of Filseta, a two-week fasting period honoring the Virgin Mary in the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. Thousands of girls in Northern Ethiopia dress in white cotton embroidered dresses and wear skirts made of tall green grass (called ashenda).

What began as a religious tradition has evolved into a vibrant cultural celebration of femininity, resilience, and community. Today, this is embraced by girls of all faiths across the region.



♣ CELEBRATIONS

Bolivia's "Cholita Wrestling" – The Fighting Cholitas

Location: El Alto, Bolivia

This is perhaps one of the most visually striking and unexpected celebrations of women. Indigenous Aymara women, called "Cholitas," dress in their traditional multilayered skirts (polleras) with bowler hats and wrestle each other

Why it's "cool": These women have transformed a symbol of oppression (the traditional dress was once forced upon them by colonizers) into a symbol of empowerment and strength. They fly through the air, body-slam opponents, and entertain crowds while wearing their cultural attire.

Slide Visual Idea: Action shot of a Cholita wrestler mid-air in full traditional dress.



✿ CELEBRATIONS

Eswatini Umhlanga (Reed Dance)

Location: Eswatini (formerly Swaziland)

Tens of thousands of young virgins gather annually to dance for the Queen Mother. They carry tall reeds and perform a carefully choreographed dance in elaborate traditional attire: colorful beads, short skirts, and impressive towering hairstyles decorated with red feathers.

Why it's "cool": The sheer scale is amazing. 25,000+ young women dancing in perfect synchronization. The festival celebrates purity, solidarity, and prepares young women for womanhood.

Slide Visual Idea: Wide shot of thousands of dancers with reeds against a beautiful landscape.



♣ CELEBRATIONS

Ireland's "Women's Christmas" (Nollaig na mBan)

Location: Ireland (celebrated nationwide), every year on January 6th .

The backstory: Traditionally, women worked tirelessly through the Christmas holidays caring for everyone. January 6th, the Feast of the Epiphany, became the day women finally got to rest. They would gather in pubs (historically a male-dominated space), visit friends' homes, and enjoy the leftover Christmas food .

How it's evolved: Today, Irish women have made it a celebration of female friendship and community



HAPPY NOLLAIG NA MBAN
(WOMEN'S CHRISTMAS)

This one's for you ladies.



✿ CELEBRATIONS

India's Raja Festival – Celebrating Menstruation

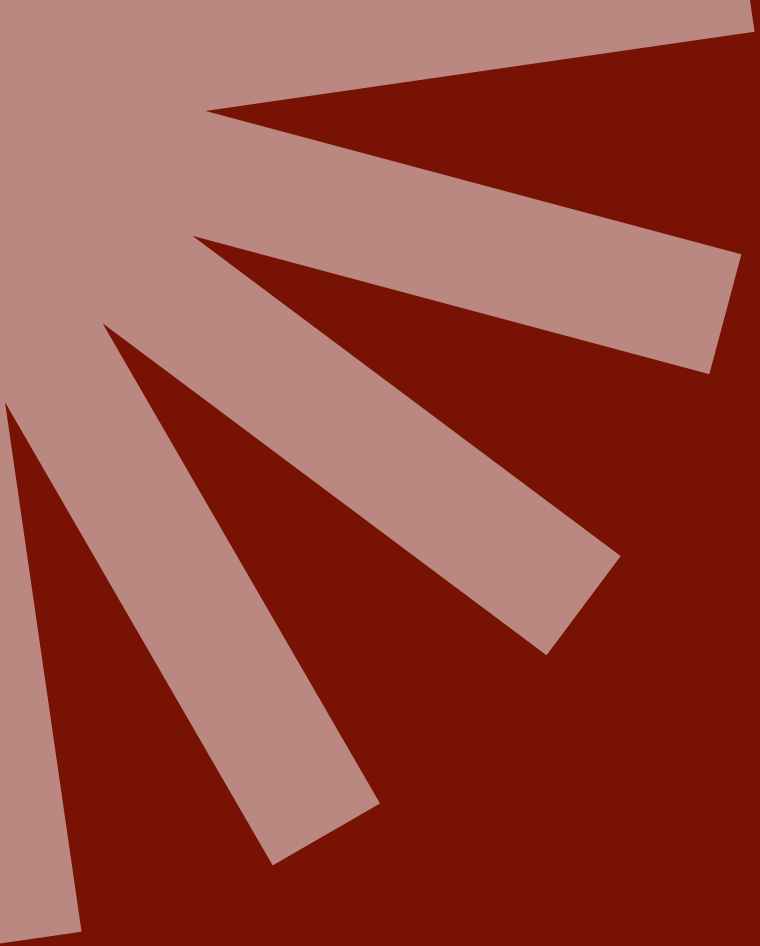
Location: Odisha, India

The Raja Festival takes place in mid-June and celebrates womanhood by honoring the menstrual cycle. According to tradition, Mother Earth herself undergoes her menstrual phase during these three days.

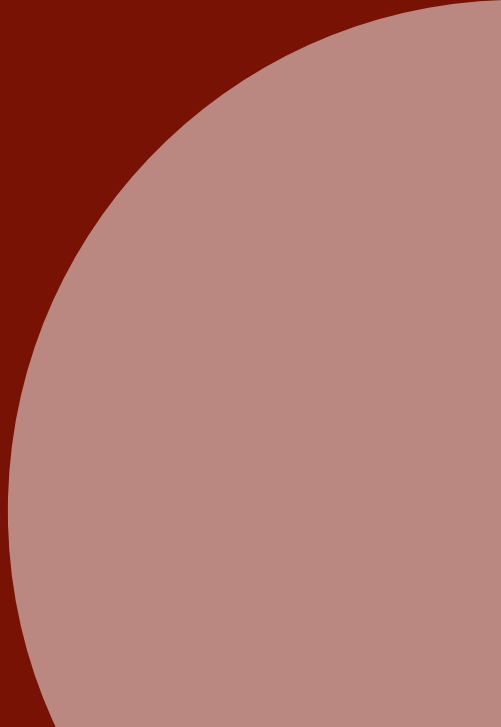
How it's celebrated:

- Rest and pampering: Girls and women take a break
- New clothes: Everyone gets new outfits
- Feet adorned with alta (a red dye traditionally applied to women's feet)
- Swings are set up as a sign of vitality





GLOBAL PERSPECTIVES



ABORTION RIGHTS

No Universal Standard

Key Points:

- Abortion laws vary dramatically around the world—from complete bans to full access on request
- Public health guidance and human rights standards recommend that countries decriminalize abortion and legalize abortion care to ensure quality, human rights-consistent care
- But the reality? A complex patchwork of laws, policies, and barriers
- The trend: Some regions are rapidly expanding access (Latin America) while others are restricting it (parts of the U.S., Poland)

ABORTION RIGHTS: NORDIC COUNTRIES: EXPORTING ABORTION RIGHTS?

What's unique:

Nordic countries (Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, Sweden) have **consistent, long-term support** for abortion rights—unlike the U.S., which shifts with each administration.

At the UN:

- Nordic governments actively pressure other nations to liberalize abortion laws
- Iceland generates about **20% of all UN recommendations** on abortion liberalization
- They push for: legalization, decriminalization, limiting conscientious objection, and comprehensive sex education

Why it matters:

They're among the top funders of the UN Population Fund (UNFPA) and UN Women, promoting reproductive rights globally

ABORTION RIGHTS: REGRESSION IN THE USA

The current landscape:

- Since the overturn of Roe v. Wade, states have set their own policies
- **Bans:** More than a dozen Republican-led states have banned most abortions
- **Protections:** Blue states have moved to preserve and expand access

Recent development (Feb 2026):

- Federal spending package renewed ban on using federal funds for abortions (except rape/incest/life endangerment)
- Missouri passed the "Born-Alive Abortion Survivors Protection Act."
- Virginia proposed a constitutional amendment to protect reproductive freedom—voters will decide

ABORTION RIGHTS: 2 CASE STUDIES

Greece's law: Fully legalized since 1986

By trimester :

- **Up to 12 weeks:** On-demand
- **Up to 19 weeks:** In case of rape or incest
- **Up to 24 weeks:** Fetal abnormalities
- **Anytime:** Risk to woman's life or serious physical/mental health damage

For minors: Under 18 need written parental/guardian permission

Rate: 7.2 abortions per 1,000 women (2007 data)

El Salvador's law: Fully criminalized with no exceptions since 1998

Not legal access at any stage: Abortion is completely banned—including for rape, incest, fetal abnormalities, or risk to the woman's life

Historical context: Before 1998, abortion was legal in cases of rape, risk to the woman's life, and severe fetal abnormalities

Penalties: Women can be sentenced to up to 40. Minors are treated the same as adults under the law; no exceptions

Rate: Unknown (illegal, so no official data), but over 180 women prosecuted since 1998

ABORTION RIGHTS: DISCUSSION

1. Why do you think abortion laws vary so dramatically between countries with similar levels of development?
2. Mexico's Supreme Court decriminalized abortion nationally, but 20 states still haven't changed their laws. How does this connect to our lesson about "the US is not the norm"?
3. Should access to abortion depend on which state or region you live in?
4. The Nordic countries actively promote abortion rights globally through UN pressure and funding. Is this a form of cultural imposition—or human rights advocacy?

#METOO MOVEMENT:

This was the first time women globally came to a consensus about what they wanted

The Origins:

African American survivor and activist Tarana Burke founded the "Me Too" movement in 2006 as a grassroots response to the sexual violence she witnessed among Black women and girls in her community. Then, October 2017 Actor Alyssa Milano tweeted: "If all the women who have been sexually harassed or assaulted wrote 'Me Too' as a status, we might give people a sense of the magnitude of the problem" .

Within 24 hours:

- 12 million Facebook posts using #MeToo
- 4.7 million people engaged in the first day
- 85+ countries reached
- 45% of U.S. users had a friend who posted #MeToo

#METOO MOVEMENT:

This was the first time women globally came to a consensus about what they wanted

The internet created instant global solidarity: Social media allowed women to transcend borders, cultures, and classes in a single moment of collective witness.

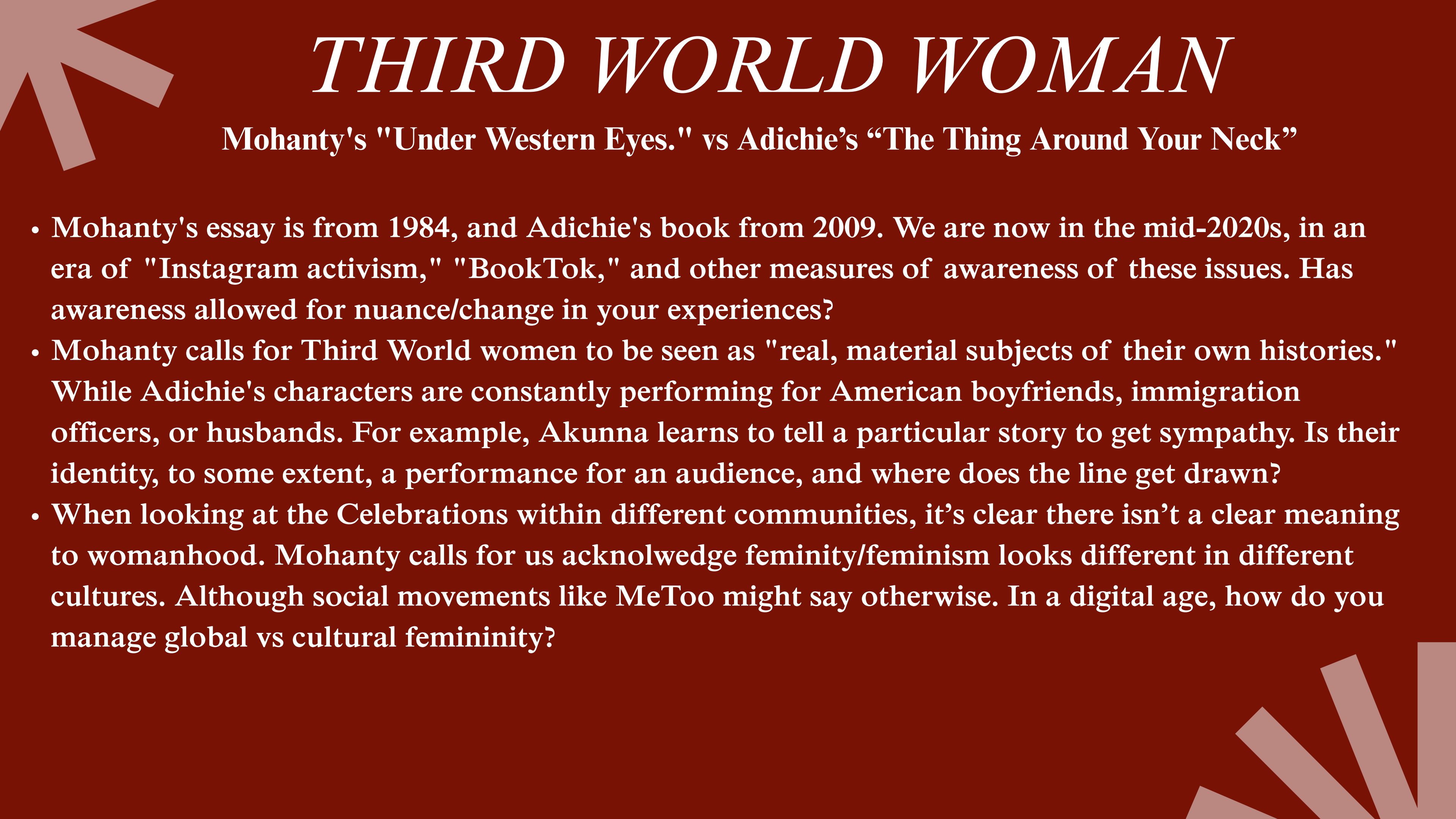
Local variations emerged worldwide – The movement was adapted, not copied:

- **France:** #BalanceTonPorc ("Rat out your pig")
- **China:** #MiTu
- **Turkey:** #SendeAnlat ("Tell your story")
- **Global South:** Movements blended with local feminist struggles

Intersectional solidarity – For the first time, conversations connected sexual violence across race, class, geography, and religion—from Hollywood to domestic workers to Indigenous communities.

The background is a solid dark red color. In the top-left corner, there is a cluster of several light red, elongated, triangular shapes radiating outwards. In the bottom-right corner, there are two overlapping light red circular shapes, partially cut off by the edge of the frame.

READING DISCUSSIONS



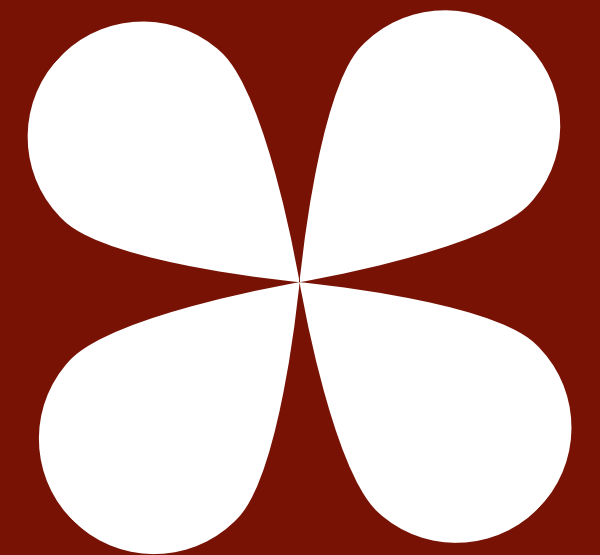
THIRD WORLD WOMAN

Mohanty's "Under Western Eyes." vs Adichie's "The Thing Around Your Neck"

- Mohanty's essay is from 1984, and Adichie's book from 2009. We are now in the mid-2020s, in an era of "Instagram activism," "BookTok," and other measures of awareness of these issues. Has awareness allowed for nuance/change in your experiences?
- Mohanty calls for Third World women to be seen as "real, material subjects of their own histories." While Adichie's characters are constantly performing for American boyfriends, immigration officers, or husbands. For example, Akunna learns to tell a particular story to get sympathy. Is their identity, to some extent, a performance for an audience, and where does the line get drawn?
- When looking at the Celebrations within different communities, it's clear there isn't a clear meaning to womanhood. Mohanty calls for us acknowledge femininity/feminism looks different in different cultures. Although social movements like MeToo might say otherwise. In a digital age, how do you manage global vs cultural femininity?

✿ UPCOMING ASSIGNMENTS

- a. Write a 100 to 250-word reflection on what you are most interested in learning in this course (based on the syllabus and our first class) and suggest a topic that you would have incorporated into our syllabus.
- b. Create an outline of the research questions about your topic for your final project.
 - i. Do some initial research and find 1 reading you want to highlight. Make sure this reading lends itself to different discussion questions.



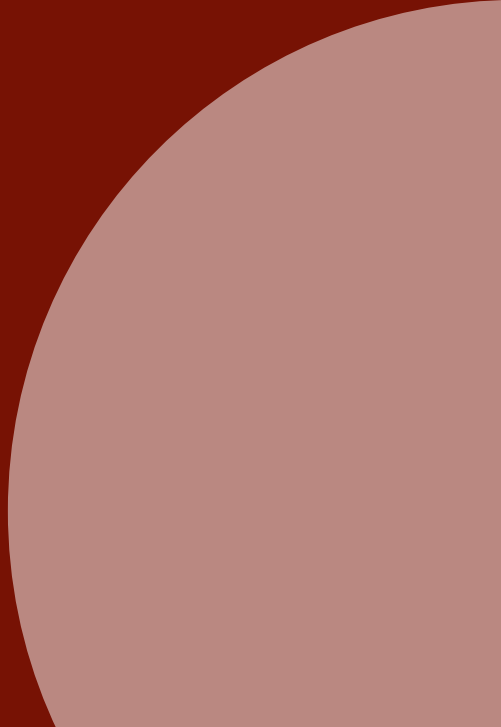
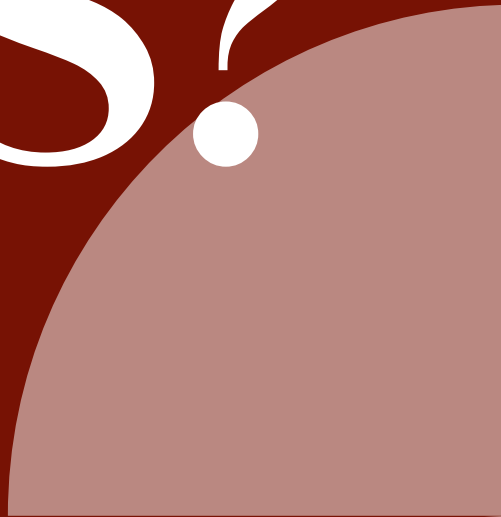


ANY QUESTIONS?

Contact us via email:

yte@duke.edu

cg352@duke.edu



THANK
YOU

